DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Did God Join a Soul to a Body?

Daat Tevunot §59-72

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §59-72 (opening of section 4) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Tuesday 17 January 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A new section: the nature of man

This class began section 4 (page 142 in the green books). The Rabbi said it will speak a great deal about tehiyat hametim, the resurrection of the dead, and about the soul and the body.

The Neshamah says: we have discussed the purpose of creation, the Yihud Hashem, and the time of its concealment. Now I want to understand the nature of the human being. The Sekhel agrees. Man is the purpose and pinnacle of all of God's works, and he is the one who has to do the work of perfecting what is imperfect. Only someone who understands man will understand everything else.

Three topics, and why we start at the end

The Neshamah lists three things to discuss: the essence of man, man's actions, and the consequences of those actions. The Sekhel says he will give only the headlines and leave the rest for the wise to examine.

Then, surprisingly, he begins with the resurrection. The Rabbi explained why by first reminding the group what olam haba means. It is not the interim world of souls, Gan Eden and Gehinnom, where the soul waits after death. Olam haba is the final stage, which begins with tehiyat hametim, when body and soul are reunited. The Ramhal is starting with the consequences, the end, in order to work back to man's essence and his actions. As one participant put it, where you end up determines what you need to do now.

§67-68: why must the body be resurrected?

The Neshamah asks the question it had raised at the start of the book: if the essence of a human being is the soul, why reunite it with the body for olam haba?

The Sekhel's answer is simple. God made body and soul to serve Him together. The body is what pulls towards earthly matters, and the soul pulls the other way; that tug of war is what gives us free choice. Since the body and the soul toiled together in this world, it is fitting that they receive the reward together. "It is not possible that the body should toil and not receive." God never withholds the reward of any creature.

The Ramhal adds that we will need to understand three moments in the bond of body and soul: when they join at birth, when they separate at death, and when they reunite at the resurrection.

The Ramhal and the Rambam

The Rabbi called this a fundamental point of the Ramhal's theology. The real olam haba is eternal delight of body and soul together, and this is the position of most of the Rishonim. He noted that the Rambam disagrees: for him the world to come is of souls alone, and the body belongs only to this world.

The Rabbi said he believes the two positions can be reconciled, and that this will become clearer as we go through the Ramhal. "The question is what does body mean."

§69-70: why two parts and not one?

The Neshamah presses further: God could have made man a single being. Why a combination of two?

The Sekhel recalls that the purpose of creation is for God to bestow good, through man refining his actions and perfecting himself. So God made the body thick, dark and lowly, unable by itself to have any spiritual encounter. This body drives our desires and makes us susceptible to every test. Against it, He made the pure soul, which in the metaphor of Hazal is hewn from beneath the Throne of Glory, and blew it into the body, as the Torah says, "He blew into his nostrils the breath of life".

The Ramhal stresses that it was never God's long term intention for the soul to live in the body as they are now, in constant contradiction. The soul entered the body in order to refine and elevate it, until the body itself reaches the level of the angels.

A refined body: Moshe, Hanokh and Eliyahu

The Rabbi gave examples. When Moshe came down from the mountain his face radiated so that the people were afraid to approach him, and he had to cover it with a veil. He still had a face and hands and limbs, but "that body was a body which was completely elevated and refined".

So too Hanokh and Eliyahu, of whom we say they ascended with their bodies. "How on earth can a body enter heaven?" The body we are born with cannot. But a body that has been refined can, and that is what happened with them.

How does the soul refine the body? Only through doing God's will: Torah study and the practice of misvot. That brings a double merit: the body is refined, and God's wish to bestow good is fulfilled.

The Rabbi summarised the human essence: a body pulling down towards our animal drives and a soul pulling up towards the spiritual, combined. The task is for them to work in sync, with the soul elevating the body. A life in which the body simply pulls towards physical desires leaves people unsatisfied: "there's conflict all the time".

§71-72: what does the soul gain?

The Neshamah now asks: I understand how this perfects the body. But the soul comes in pure. What does it gain?

The Sekhel says he will return to this. For now, the main purpose of the soul in this world is to refine the body so that it can be resurrected in a refined state. He cites the Zohar: when the body is in this world it lacks perfection, and when it does what is right it is considered perfected through the soul. By elevating the body, the soul does the will of God.

The Rabbi ended with the obvious next question. If that were the whole story, a person who did everything right should go straight to olam haba without dying. Why do we need death at all? The answer, to come next time, involves the sin of Adam.

Summary

- Section 4 turns to man: his essence, his actions and their consequences, starting from the end, the resurrection.
- Olam haba is not the interim world of souls but body and soul reunited after tehiyat hametim; the Rambam holds it is soul alone, but the Rabbi believes they can be reconciled.
- The body shares in the reward because it shared in the toil.
- God joined a pure soul to a lowly body so that the soul would refine the body through Torah and misvot, up to the level of the angels, as with Moshe, Hanokh and Eliyahu.
- Next: why death is still necessary, which goes back to the sin of Adam.

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